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The value of CEO communication on social media for internal relationship management and employees' social media engagement

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Abstract

Purpose – The purpose of this study is to explore how CEOs' interpersonal communication styles on social media can effectively enhance the relationship with employees and increase their engagement on social media platforms.

Design/methodology/approach – An online survey was conducted with 404 full-time employees working in corporations across various industries in the US. Only employees who "follow" their company's CEO on social media were included in the study.

Findings – CEOs' use of a conversational tone on social media helps employees perceive them as approachable and interactive leaders, thereby improving the quality of the CEO-employee relationship and increasing employees' engagement on social media. CEOs' personal disclosures on social media were found to promote employees' perceptions of CEO approachability only when paired with a conversational communication style.

Research limitations/implications – Our study offers theoretical implications for communication and media literature by highlighting the potential of CEOs as chief "engagement" officers, capable of leveraging online platforms (i.e. social media) to foster employee interactions and support.

Practical implications – This study provides CEOs and communication practitioners with practical guidelines for using social media for both professional and social purposes as a crucial tool for internal relationship management.

Originality/value – This study is one of the first empirical attempts to examine the value of CEO social media communication as a key tool for building and maintaining quality employee–CEO relationship and engagement.

Keywords CEO social media, Conversational human voice, Social presence, Self-disclosure, Leadership communication, Internal relations

Paper type Research paper

Introduction

Social media, with its immediate, interactive, and relationship-focused features, has enabled organizational leaders to engage with their stakeholders in a more personalized manner (Zhong *et al.*, 2011). As an increasing number of CEOs have utilized social media channels to humanize their presence and communicate with the tech-savvy public, CEOs' use of social media and its impact on the public has been widely studied in recent years (Kim and Sung, 2021; Tsai and Men, 2017; Yue *et al.*, 2021). Employees now rely on social media not only to advocate on behalf of their organizations but also to interact with their organizations and leaders (Lee and Kim, 2021). In fact, employees have specific expectations for their CEOs on social media, anticipating them to be accessible, engaging, and emotionally connected (Kelleher *et al.*, 2019). While CEOs' voices on social media facilitate effective communication with employees, few studies have examined the dynamics of CEOs' social media presence and how internal members respond to it.

CEOs play a crucial role in shaping how companies communicate internally, significantly influencing the organization's culture and connecting with employees. A rich body of

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literature suggests that when CEOs communicate strategically, it boosts employee engagement, strengthens the relationship between employees and the organization, and encourages actions that benefit the company (Lee and Dong, 2023; Men, 2021). Scholars have particularly highlighted CEOs' use of various communication channels to effectively engage with employees, including social media channels (Lee, 2022). Social media helps employees feel connected, build networks with coworkers, feel proud of their employers, and be satisfied with their jobs (Huang and Liu, 2017). Therefore, CEOs have increasingly used social media to better interact with employees and position themselves as approachable, friendly, and inclusive leaders (Tsai and Men, 2017). Similarly, social media has become an important tool for CEOs to represent their leadership characteristics (e.g. approachability, interactivity) to their employees. Additionally, in response to increasing public expectations, more and more CEOs are advocating for and disclosing their private lives as well as their personal opinions on sociopolitical issues via social media channels (Cycyota, 2023; Kim and Sung, 2021). These trends in CEOs' social media usage offer unique insights into how brands should use social media to communicate with and build relationships with strategic stakeholders. Given that CEOs' evolved and nuanced usage of social media may change the dynamics of the CEO-employee relationship, scholarly attention is needed to understand how internal members perceive CEOs' diverse social media communication styles. To fill this gap in the existing literature, this study aims to provide insights into CEOs' social media communication as a tool for internal relationship management, focusing on their conversational communication style and self-disclosure.

Communication studies have long highlighted the importance of an interpersonal approach to social media communications. CEOs' interpersonal communication approach on social media has been found to positively influence public engagement and advocacy (Tsai and Men, 2017). In general, the social dimension of using social media includes social presence and self-presentation/self-disclosure (Kaplan and Haenlein, 2010). Social presence is a media-related component that emphasizes the importance of interpersonal relationships within a medium, determined by its interactivity (Fortin and Dholakia, 2005), while self-disclosure pertains to how social media allows individuals to express their identities by revealing personal information. In the context of CEOs' social media communication, first, CEOs' social presence can be represented by their use of conversational human voice (CHV), which refers to an engaging and natural style of organizational communication perceived by the public (Kelleher, 2009). CHV has been considered a crucial communication strategy in the digital environment. Extending this idea, we propose a conceptual model that examines how CEOs' conversational human voice positively influences CEO-employee relationship and employees' engagement on social media by enhancing their perceptions of CEOs' attributes, namely approachability and interactivity.

Second, CEOs' use of social media to share their personal lives and opinions is considered self-disclosing behavior (Yue *et al.*, 2021). In general, self-disclosure on social media by public figures (e.g. celebrities, politicians) positively influences relational outcomes between the parties (e.g. Lee *et al.*, 2018). Studies have suggested that in interpersonal relationships, self-disclosure generates positive outcomes only when it is perceived as appropriate behavior (Collins and Miller, 1994). CEOs' personal disclosure has been found to influence favorable consumer evaluations of the CEO and the brand when consumers have communal relational norms (Kim and Sung, 2021). As an effort to contribute to this line of research, we aim to understand when CEOs' self-disclosure on social media is evaluated favorably by employees by investigating its moderating effect.

In sum, drawing from social presence theory and social penetration theory, the current research aims to examine how CEOs' social media communication style influences the way employees respond to and evaluate their CEOs' attributes in both online and offline settings. The results of this study will provide much-needed theoretical contributions to the understanding of CEOs' computer-mediated communication via social media and its internal impacts. Our research enriches social presence theory by applying its tenets in a

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leadership context and advances social penetration theory by examining CEOs' personal disclosure on social media as a tool for internal relationship management. This research will also offer practical guidelines for senior leaders on how to utilize social media for effective internal relations and improve employee engagement.

Literature review

Social presence of CEOs

In recent years, top organizational leaders, particularly CEOs, have increasingly embraced social media as a primary channel for communication, connection, and interaction with key stakeholders. Notably, 70% of Fortune 500 CEOs are currently active on at least one major social media platform, an increase from 62% in 2020 (McIvor, 2022). LinkedIn stands out as their preferred platform, with 97% of the 352 active Fortune 500 CEOs utilizing it. While Twitter and Instagram are somewhat less favored, they are gaining ground, experiencing increases of over 100% and 133%, respectively, among Fortune 500 leaders from 2020 to 2022 (Marlatt, 2022).

The growing acknowledgment of social media's value by CEOs is influenced by various factors, with stakeholder expectations at the forefront. In today's business landscape, employees, customers, investors, and donors expect business leaders to embody openness, authenticity, and transparency in their communications (Ji and Hong, 2023). Stakeholders seek direct interactions with top executives to gain insights into the organization's vision, mission, values, and future directions (Men *et al.*, 2018). Furthermore, some stakeholders now expect CEOs to leverage their personal platforms to address social and political issues (Yue *et al.*, 2021).

Scholars in communication, public relations, and business have identified several relational, engagement, reputational, and financial advantages stemming from CEOs' direct interactions with diverse audiences on social media (e.g. Alghawi *et al.*, 2014; Huang and Yeo, 2018; Men *et al.*, 2018; Yue *et al.*, 2023). The public tends to cultivate parasocial relationships with CEOs through social media interactions. Parasocial relationships refer to the intimate, albeit illusory, connections that the public forms with media personalities, such as celebrities, CEOs, and other public figures, through media channels. This quasi-intimate connection influences people's trust, satisfaction, and advocacy for the company (Tsai and Men, 2017). In particular, employees are more likely to feel motivated and inspired to advocate for their organizations externally due to the modeling role of CEOs in sharing company news, values, and thought leadership. Executives on social media platforms provide a direct channel for internal members, prospective hires, current and potential customers, investors, and others to offer feedback directly to the CEO for necessary changes. For instance, enterprise social media platforms, embedded with interactive and relational features, allow CEOs to actively exchange ideas with employees, respond to questions promptly, communicate genuinely and personally, and facilitate upward communication from employees.

CEO voice: conversational human voice (CHV)

Unlike corporate accounts typically managed by social media and public relations teams, which often struggle to engage online audiences due to content overload, generic promotional messaging, and a perceived lack of authenticity, posts by top management tend to garner significantly higher engagement rates (Liu, 2018). The public expects CEOs to participate in authentic and transparent dialogues using a human tone, rather than simply delivering organizational messages akin to those found in official press releases. CEOs' social media messages can focus on their organizations and professional roles while still benefiting from being personable, relatable, and interactive. This can be achieved by personalizing and humanizing corporate news, infusing it with an engaging and natural style of communication. In this study, we rely on the concept of CHV, a communication style extensively researched in

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online organizational and brand communication (Kelleher, 2009; Kelleher and Miller, 2006; Liebrecht *et al.*, 2021), to investigate the impact of CEOs' communication style on social media.

Over the past decade, the use and impact of CHV have undergone thorough examination in corporate communication, public relations, and marketing communications (Liebrecht *et al.*, 2021). CHV is defined as "an engaging and natural style of organizational communication as perceived by an organization's public based on interactions between individuals in the organization and individuals in the public" (Kelleher, 2009, p. 177). The key attributes of CHV are humanness and closeness, which form the bedrock of the concept (Kelleher, 2009). Notably, CHV finds its roots in social presence theory, which is defined as "the extent to which a person is perceived as a real person in mediated communication" (Gunawardena, 1995, p. 151). This theory has found application in both organizational and leadership communication, exemplified by studies exploring how CEOs employ affective, interactive, and cohesive strategies to enhance their social presence on platforms like Facebook and Twitter (Men *et al.*, 2018; Yue *et al.*, 2019, 2021).

In general, organizations can cultivate CHV in their communication by adjusting the content and language features of their messages in three distinct ways: message personalization, informal speech, and invitational rhetoric (van Noort *et al.*, 2014). Message personalization involves spotlighting the individuals behind the organization or the intended message receiver; informal speech encompasses a casual language style akin to everyday conversation; and invitational rhetoric is marked by inclusive statements such as "Let us know what you think" (Decock *et al.*, 2021, p. 5). Building on this, Liebrecht *et al.* (2021) developed a taxonomy that identifies seventeen subcategories within the three primary CHV tactics. The study also highlights that brands can enhance their appeal as engaging conversational partners by incorporating various linguistic elements of CHV into their messages. Decock *et al.* (2021) further explored the linguistic tactics that can enhance the perception of CHV. They suggested that message personalization can be achieved not only by including individual names and pronouns and adapting to a person's language style but also by varying the wording across organizational responses to give the impression of tailoring each response to the individual's needs.

Research has recognized CHV as an effective relational cultivation strategy that can foster positive interactions, organization-public relationships, public engagement, corporate reputation, and various other favorable organizational outcomes (e.g. Barcelos *et al.*, 2018; Huang and Ki, 2023; Men and Tsai, 2016; Park and Cameron, 2014). For instance, Sung and Kim (2021) suggested that using communication strategies centered on interpersonal approaches—such as responding to customer comments to boost interaction, mimicking interpersonal communication, and adopting a conversational tone—enhances the perception of the organization as more personified. This, in turn, strengthens the customer's belief that the organization is actively investing in their relationship, also known as perceived relationship investment. However, it is worth noting that non- or opposite effects have also been documented (e.g. Jahng and Hong, 2017). These mixed findings can be attributed to Kelleher's definition of CHV, which allows for multiple interpretations in operationalizing CHV (Liebrecht *et al.*, 2021). Nevertheless, there is a consensus that, to fully harness the potential of strategic online communication, organizations should embrace a human tone of voice on their social media sites rather than adopting a purely corporate tone.

While the bulk of research has concentrated on the application of CHV to the examination of online organizational communication, this concept is equally relevant for CEOs engaging on social media. Employing a natural and personalized tone of voice not only allows organizations to present themselves as authentic human entities (Barcelos *et al.*, 2018) but also enables CEOs to cultivate a greater sense of intimacy and immediacy with their followers. Supporting this point, Kelleher *et al.* (2019) found that employees' perceptions of a CEO's use of CHV on social media positively impact their views on CEO authentic leadership and organizational transparency.

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Extending this line of research, in the following section, we elaborate on what we consider to be the immediate outcomes of CHV: the perceived CEO interactivity and approachability. According to social presence theory, social media has enabled CEOs to achieve greater social presence in engaging the public by building intimate relationships, which generates positive relational outcomes (Tsai and Men, 2017). With the increased expectations of key stakeholders, CEOs adopt social media to exhibit their sociability, openness, and accessibility. With spontaneous, interactive, and communal features, social media enables CEOs to amplify their personal approach to communicate with their stakeholders. CEOs' characteristics of interactivity and approachability have been suggested as key factors in showcasing successful leadership with today's public and resonating with their main purpose of using social media (Alghawi *et al.*, 2014; Men and Tsai, 2016). Therefore, we chose interactivity and approachability as the major outcomes of CEOs' CHV on social media.

Hypotheses development

Perceived CEO interactivity. Simply put, perceived interactivity refers to a user's subjective evaluation of how interactive an experience or an interaction feels overall. Prior literature approaches interactivity from two main perspectives: functional interactivity and contingency, the latter also known as user-based interactivity (Rafaeli and Ariel, 2007). Functional interactivity is characterized as "based more on promoting an appearance of interactivity and does not adequately specify the outcomes of interactive communication" (Sundar *et al.*, 2003, p. 34). Challenging this functional perspective, Rafaeli (1988) introduced a definition of interactivity as user responsiveness, where iterative conversational processes lead to jointly produced meaning between communicators. Interactivity encompasses the likelihood of engagement in interaction, including the perceived ease of interaction and the degree of rapport that is activated (Rafaeli, 1988). In alignment with this research, Thorson and Rodgers (2006, p. 36) defined perceived interactivity as "the extent to which users perceive their experience as a simulation of interpersonal interaction and sense they are in the presence of a social other."

We assert that employees' perceptions of the CEO's interactivity are enhanced when the CEO demonstrates openness to dialogue, encourages conversational communication, offers prompt feedback, addresses criticism directly but constructively, communicates with a sense of humor, admits mistakes, and treats others with a human touch on social media. Although the literature has not explicitly delved into this specific relationship, it has provided insights into the correlation between different facets of CHV and the perceived interactivity of the communicator. For example, Thorson and Rodgers (2006) observed that perceptions of interactivity can be influenced by the presence of a single interactive element on a website. In their study, this interactive element was a hyperlink that provided the opportunity to post public feedback on a political candidate's blog. Moreover, Park and Cameron (2014) found that participants perceived a blog as more interactive when written in a human voice and included personal stories, as opposed to an organizational voice. Adding to this understanding, Yang *et al.* (2010) found that individual audiences, when engaged with a narrative message featuring openness to dialogic communication, perceived higher interactivity. Additionally, Chattaraman *et al.* (2019) established that an AI-based digital assistant with an informal, conversational style while guiding older users on tasks enhanced perceived social outcomes, including increased interactivity and trust in the online system. Given this empirical foundation, we posit the following hypothesis:

H1. CEOs' use of conversational human voice on social media increases employees' perceived CEO interactivity.

Perceived CEO approachability. Approachability refers to the perception that a source is warm, caring, and easy to talk to or meet (Perrine, 1998). It signals to others that they can approach the communicator, fostering an attitude that encourages communication.

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In interpersonal communication, approachable individuals are often relaxed, use gestures, smile, make eye contact, and display openness (Slater, 2008). Pack *et al.* (2022) identified three key pillars of approachability: availability/presence, uncertainty/thinking aloud, and vulnerability. Presence is essential for approachability, as it signals a willingness to engage and listen. The aspect of uncertainty, conveyed through thinking aloud and sharing one's mental model, helps prevent disagreements and builds trust in ambiguous situations. Finally, vulnerability, demonstrated by admitting mistakes or missteps, plays a critical role in enhancing approachability (Pack *et al.*, 2022).

In educational settings, approachable instructors are recognized for going beyond their standard duties, such as learning students' names, showing genuine interest in their work, and encouraging students to seek help when needed (Perrine, 1998). Similarly, when CEOs cultivate an online presence and actively engage on social media, it signals their willingness and ability to connect with stakeholders. Men and Tsai (2016) provided empirical evidence supporting the positive relationship between public engagement by CEOs on social media and their perceived approachability.

Building on this research, we propose that organizational leaders can be perceived as more approachable by employees if they exhibit behaviors aligned with the traits identified in previous studies. These behaviors include adopting a conversational tone, demonstrating genuine interest in stakeholders, sharing authentic opinions and thought leadership, and displaying openness, transparency, and occasional vulnerability—characteristics that align with CHV. Based on these insights, we hypothesize the following:

H2. CEOs' use of conversational human voice on social media increases employees' perceived CEO approachability.

In the next section, we will explore the outcomes of CEOs' use of CHV on social media, focusing specifically on its impact on the CEO-employee relationship and employees' engagement on social media.

CEO-employee relationship. As a critical outcome of CEO communication on social media, this study focuses on the CEO-employee relationship. In management and public relations literature, employee-organization relationships (EORs) have generally been defined as "the degree to which an organization and its employees trust one another, agree on who has the rightful power to influence, experience satisfaction with each other, and commit oneself to the other" (Men and Stacks, 2014, p. 307). This definition is drawn from organization-public relationships (OPRs), which include four key components—trust, control mutuality, commitment, and satisfaction. These components reflect the relational quality between an organization and the public (Hon and Grunig, 1999). Scholars have long recognized the importance of these quality relationships as key managerial and communication outcomes (e.g. Lee, 2022; Men, 2021). Employees often view their relationship with leaders as reflective of their overall relationship with the organization. Therefore, we adopt this definition to conceptualize the CEO-employee relationship in this context. In the computer-mediated communication setting, relational trust and relational satisfaction have been identified as the most relevant outcomes of OPRs (Men and Tsai, 2016; Tsai and Men, 2017). As such, this study also considers employees' levels of trust and satisfaction with their CEOs as essential measures of CEO-employee relationship quality.

We expect that employees' perceived interactivity and approachability of CEO communication can increase the quality of the relationship with their CEOs. In interpersonal communication settings that involve power dynamics between two parties (e.g. teacher-student, subordinate-supervisor), approachability is a major factor in building high-quality relationships (Porter *et al.*, 2007). Similarly, approachability plays a central role for senior leaders in establishing and maintaining meaningful relationships with stakeholders, particularly via social media. Social media offers the public direct and open access to CEO communication activities, a form of interaction that is often less accessible offline. We believe that the use of a conversational and human tone on social media helps CEOs appear more

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approachable and less remote, which in turn positively influences employee trust and satisfaction with their leadership. This approach not only makes CEOs more relatable but also fosters a sense of inclusivity and engagement among employees.

Furthermore, today's employees expect their leaders to listen actively, engage interactively, and communicate responsively and frequently (Men, 2021). When employees observe their CEOs communicating in a conversational and interactive manner, they are more likely to perceive their CEOs as caring leaders who are genuinely invested in their well-being and success. This positive perception leads to greater trust and satisfaction with leadership. CEOs who interact regularly with employees make them feel appreciated and listened to, reinforcing the view that these leaders are effective listeners and strengthening the CEO-employee relationship. Based on these insights, we propose the following hypotheses:

H3. Employees' perceived CEO interactivity increases the CEO-employee relationship.

H4. Employees' perceived CEO approachability increases the CEO-employee relationship.

Employee social media engagement. Employees are undoubtedly a critical internal stakeholder group, and their social media engagement is vital to an organization's effectiveness and long-term business success. This engagement amplifies the reach and significance of corporate messages, directly contributing to the achievement of the company's objectives (Jiang *et al.*, 2022). As a central construct in public relations, engagement refers to the time and effort the public is willing to voluntarily invest in interacting with an organization.

Scholars have used several behavioral indicators to delineate the level of public engagement, ranging from passive content consumption to active content contributions on social media (Men *et al.*, 2018). Following this approach, Smith *et al.* (2017) defined employee social media engagement as the absorption, experience, and related behavioral responses of employees. Examples of such social media engagement include pressing the "like" button, sharing videos, and commenting on them (Alhabash *et al.*, 2015). In an organizational setting, the concept of employees' social media engagement has expanded from reactive behaviors (i.e. liking, sharing, commenting) to proactive ones, such as advocacy. Advocacy refers to employees' voluntary verbal and nonverbal expressions of support, recommendations, or defense of an organization or its products/services (Thelen, 2020). This advocacy behavior can be manifested on social media as a powerful tool to influence external audiences' perceptions and attitudes toward corporations because of the credibility and authenticity of employees' words (Lee and Kim, 2021). Therefore, this study considers employees' social media engagement to include behaviors not limited to liking, sharing, and commenting on content but also encompassing their advocacy behaviors on social media as representatives of their organizations. In the context of this research, we conceptualize *CEO-advocative social media engagement* as employees' reactive and proactive engagement on social media related to their CEOs' activities.

Such engagement of employees on social media may be heightened by CEOs' communication efforts. Existing literature has highlighted the role of CEOs in promoting employee engagement and advocative behaviors both offline and online (Krause, 2016; Lee and Dong, 2023). Extending this line of research, we propose that employees' perceptions of their CEOs' approachability and interactivity may enhance social media engagement. In general, perceived interactivity increases the public's acceptance of messages, favorable attitudes toward an organization, and, consequently, engagement with the message (Yang *et al.*, 2010). A leader's open, responsive communication style also makes employees more engaged on social media (Men *et al.*, 2023). Similarly, when employees perceive their CEO as an interactive leader through social media activities, they are more likely to engage with the content and are motivated to advocate for and share positive messages using their social media networks. Regarding the effect of approachability on employee social media engagement, previous studies provide several insights. For example, CEOs' personalized posts,

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characterized by high levels of affection, emotional expression, and glimpses into their personal lives, have been shown to enhance the public's engagement level (e.g. likes, shares, comments, reactions) (Men *et al.*, 2018; Yue *et al.*, 2023). Similarly, in this study, we posit that a CEO's personalized content and their CHV enable them to be perceived as more personal and approachable by employees. This perception encourages employees to feel more comfortable engaging in direct communication with the CEO. As a result, employees are empowered to interact with their leader, feel motivated to engage with the CEO's social media content, and are more likely to advocate for their employer. Therefore, we suggest the following hypotheses:

H5. Employees' perceived CEO interactivity increases employees' CEO-advocative social media engagement.

H6. Employees' perceived CEO approachability increases employees' CEO-advocative social media engagement.

The moderating role of self-disclosure. In exploring employees' perceptions of their CEOs in relation to CEOs' social media usage, we predict that CEOs' self-disclosure plays a significant role, in addition to their conversational communication style. On social media, while CEOs often represent their firms as corporate leaders and are expected to exhibit thought leadership, it has also become common practice for them to disclose their personal stories, values, and opinions (Kim and Sung, 2021; Yue *et al.*, 2021). By definition, self-disclosure refers to the act of revealing personal information about oneself to another (Collins and Miller, 1994). This concept is rooted in social penetration theory (Altman and Taylor, 1973), which suggests that revealing personal information helps build intimacy and deepen relationships between parties. The information disclosed can range from superficial to sensitive topics (e.g. political views, and religious values) (Greene *et al.*, 2006). CEOs' self-disclosure behaviors include sharing their personal traits, interests, and private lives (e.g. family life, hobbies, social views) (Denner *et al.*, 2019; Kim and Sung, 2021).

Interpersonal communication literature has long suggested that self-disclosure enhances relational satisfaction, as well as the discloser's likability and intimacy (Collins and Miller, 1994; Levesque *et al.*, 2002). This idea has been applied in computer-mediated communication settings (e.g. social media), particularly to understand leadership communication (Yue *et al.*, 2019). Since disclosure is foundational to building interpersonal relationships, public figures' (e.g. politicians, CEOs) self-disclosure on social media and its impacts on public responses have attracted scholarly attention. For example, politicians' personalized posts enhanced the public's perceived intimacy (Lee and Oh, 2012), while the personal disclosure of CEOs did not significantly increase the public's perceived likability and competence of CEOs (Yue *et al.*, 2021). However, CEOs' personal and private information has been found to help generate positive public responses (e.g. empathy and trust toward the CEO) and enhance organizational image during a crisis (Koch *et al.*, 2022). Another study found that consumers tend to perceive CEOs' personal disclosures as favorable only when they have communal relational norms with the brand (Kim and Sung, 2021). Findings from these studies suggest that CEOs' self-disclosure strategy on social media has conditional impacts on public responses, which warrants further research.

What has not been studied in prior literature, in particular, is how CEOs' personal disclosure strategy is perceived by internal members and whether it triggers positive responses from employees. We thus expect that CEOs' personal disclosure may enhance perceptions of CEOs as interactive and approachable leaders, leading us to suggest the following hypotheses:

H7. CEOs' self-disclosure on social media moderates the effects of their conversational human voice on social media on (a) CEO interactivity and (b) CEO approachability perceived by employees.

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Method

Participants

An online survey was conducted with full-time employees from various industries working in corporations in the US. To recruit the participants, we used a sampling company, Dynata, headquartered in the US., which has access to over three million panelists. With the assistance of Dynata, we obtained a sample representative of the US. census in terms of age, gender, and race/ethnicity. Qualified participants for this study (e.g. full-time employees in the US.) received invitation emails from this company to participate in a 15-min survey and received approximately $5 incentives. Upon receiving the consent form, respondents were asked whether they currently "follow" their company's CEO's social media channels. Those who answered "no" to this question were excluded from this study. We also excluded participants who did not currently use social media channels.

We had a final sample of 404 full-time employees, with 41.3% of females (n = 171) and with a mean age of 31.34 (SD = 12.94). Most participants were White/Caucasian (71.8%) and had at least a bachelor's degree (77.5%). A majority of the respondents (80%) answered that they worked at their current company for at least four years. Participants worked in various industries, including finance/insurance (14.9%), information/telecommunication (12.6%), education services (10.1%), and construction (9%), to name a few. In terms of CEOs' profile, a majority of participants had CEOs who were male (76.2%) and White/Caucasian (77%). Approximately 30.2% of them identified their CEOs' political identification as liberal and 40.1% of them responded that their CEOs are rather conservative. Regarding social media channels, Facebook (66.8%) was the most frequently used channel used by CEOs, followed by Instagram (56.2%), Twitter (52%), and LinkedIn (35.9%).

Measurements

All the items used in this study were adopted from previous literature with a 5-point Likert scale, ranging from 1 (strongly disagree) to 5 (strongly agree), except for CEOs' self-disclosure. First, CEOs' conversational human voice was measured with eight items (α = 0.919) adapted from Kelleher and Miller (2006). Perceived CEO interactivity was measured with five items (α = 0.868) adopted by McMillan and Hwang (2002). Employees' perceived CEO approachability was measured with 10 items (α = 0.925) adopted from Porter *et al.* (2007). CEO-employee relationship was measured with a total of 10 items adopted from Hon and Grunig (1999), including six items of relational trust (α = 0.908) and four items of relational satisfaction (α = 0.910) [1]. Employees' social media engagement [2] was measured with a total of seven items, including three items indicating their intentions of "like," "comment," and "share" the CEOs' social media posts and four items (α = 0.914) of advocative behaviors adopted from Walden and Westerman (2018). CEOs' self-disclosure was measured with four items (α = 0.856) we created. Based on previous studies, we included items related to the disclosure of their personal/family lives, work lives, and sociopolitical views. Items began with "On social media, how often does your company's CEO . . ." and ended with each item, using a 5-point Likert scale from 1 (Never) to 5 (Always). See Appendix for all measurement items.

Data analysis

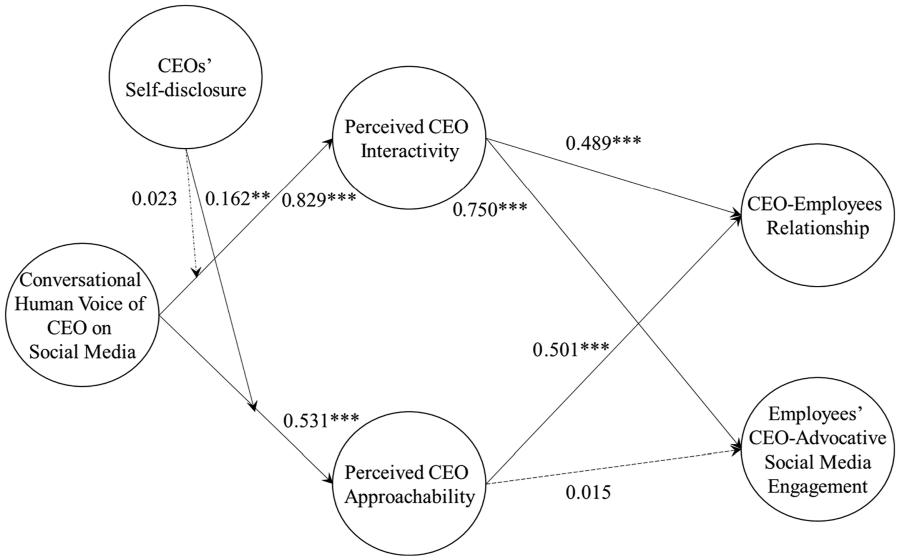
A structural equation modeling (SEM) analysis was implemented to test the proposed model (Figure 1). First, the measurement model was assessed, followed by the structural model, using the Mplus program.

Results

Preliminary data analysis

The results of the descriptive analysis (see Table 1) showed that all the variables were positively and significantly related to each other, which provides preliminary support for our

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Source(s): Authors' work

Figure 1. Hypothesized model

Table 1. Descriptive statistics and correlations among the study variables

Variables	M (SD)	1	2	3	4	5	6
1. CEO conversational human voice	4.00 (0.82)	0.769					
2. CEO self-disclosure	3.70 (0.99)	0.543**	0.794				
3. Perceived CEO interactivity	3.92 (0.95)	0.628**	0.519**	0.825			
4. Perceived CEO approachability	3.86 (0.98)	0.468**	0.171**	0.394**	0.750		
5. CEO-employee relationship	4.06 (0.89)	0.599**	0.418**	0.531**	0.557**	0.813	
6. Employees' CEO-advocative social media engagement	3.79 (1.14)	0.651**	0.535**	0.667**	0.481**	0.592**	0.803

Note(s): $^{**}p < 0.01$
Values on the diagonal area are the square root of the average variance extracted (AVE)
Source(s): Authors' work

hypotheses. We conducted a series of *t*-tests, ANOVA, and regression analysis to examine any effects of socio-demographic variables. The results of hierarchical regression analysis showed that participants' age was negatively associated with their social media engagement ($\beta = -0.017$, $p < 0.001$). Their position was positively associated with both social media engagement ($\beta = 0.293$, $p < 0.001$) and CEO-employee relationship ($\beta = 0.199$, $p < 0.001$). The ANOVA result indicated that CEOs' race/ethnicity had a significant effect on employees' perceived relationship with their CEOs ($F(4,399) = 4.30$, $p = 0.002$). No significant effect was found in terms of participants' gender, race, organizational tenure, industry, or the CEOs' gender and age. Therefore, we controlled participants' age, position at work, and CEOs' race/ethnicity in the following SEM analysis.

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Common method bias (CMB) testing

Due to the nature of the cross-sectional survey data used in this study, we evaluated the potential common method bias (CMB) (Podsakoff *et al.*, 2003) with several methods. Harman's single-factor score was first created. The total variance explained by the single factor was 33% (<50%). Next, CFA results showed that the one-factor CFA measurement model exhibited poor model fit: $\chi^2(902) = 7432.514$, RMSEA = 0.134 [0.131, 0.137], CFI = 0.553, TLI = 0.531, SRMR = 0.244 [3]. Finally, upper variance inflation factor (VIF) values were created, following Kock and Lynn's (2012) approach. The threshold value of the highest VIF score is 5 to be free of CMB in SEM models. We found that the score was 3.03, which is less than 5. Therefore, we conclude that the CMB is not a serious threat to our data.

SEM analysis

Model specification. In the SEM model, CEOs' conversational human voice, self-disclosure, perceived CEO interactivity, and perceived CEO approachability were specified as unidimensional reflective constructs. That is, they were latent variables indicated by eight, four, ten, and five items respectively. CEO-employee relationship was specified as a second-order formative construct indicated by two first-order constructs: trust and satisfaction. Finally, employees' social media engagement was operationalized as a second-order factor formative construct with first-order reflective measures of social media engagement (e.g. like, share, comment) and advocacy. Overall, the CFA model includes two second-order factors and four first-order factors.

Testing measurement and structural model. The results of the CFA model showed satisfactory model fits: $\chi^2(515) = 1187.621$, CFI = 0.943, TLI = 0.937, RMSEA = 0.061 [0.057, 0.065], SRMR = 0.044. All factor loading values were greater than 0.5 at the $p < 0.001$ level. We then examined the construct validity (Table 2). The composite reliabilities (CR) for all the latent variables were higher than 0.6 (ranging from 0.871 to 0.928) and the average variance extracted (AVE) values were also greater than the threshold value of 0.5 (ranging from 0.562 to 0.716). In addition, the values of the square root values of AVE were all higher than the construct correlations. The convergent and discriminant validity of the measures were thus shown to be satisfactory. Next, the structural model was tested. The model showed satisfactory model fits ($\chi^2(517) = 1197.975$, CFI = 0.942, TLI = 0.936, RMSEA = 0.061 [0.057, 0.065], SRMR = 0.044). Through nested model comparison, we compared the baseline model with several alternative models. We added direct paths from CEOs' CHV on social media to CEO-employee relationship, to employees' social media engagement, and both, in the first, second, and third alternative models, respectively. All three alternative models did not show better model fits than the baseline model. The direct paths were all found to be insignificant. Moreover, in the fourth alternative model, we added the direct path from CEO-employee relationship to social media engagement. The model fit was not significantly better than the original model and the path was insignificant. Therefore, we selected the baseline model (Figure 1) that hypothesized the *full* mediation effects of approachability and interactivity as the final model and interpreted the path coefficients (see Figure 2).

Hypotheses testing. In H1 and H2, we examined the association between CEOs' use of CHV on social media and employees' perceived interactivity and approachability of CEOs. Both paths were found to be positive and significant (H1: $\beta = 0.829$, $p < 0.001$; H2: $\beta = 0.531$, $p < 0.001$). H1 and H2 are thus supported. H3 and H4 investigated the relationships between employees' perceived interactivity and approachability of their CEOs and CEO-employee relationship. Results showed that both interactivity ($\beta = 0.489$, $p < 0.001$) and approachability ($\beta = 0.501$, $p < 0.001$) were positively associated with CEO-employee relationship, supporting H3 and H4.

H5 and H6 tested the associations between employees' perceived interactivity and approachability of their CEOs and employees' social media engagement. While perceived

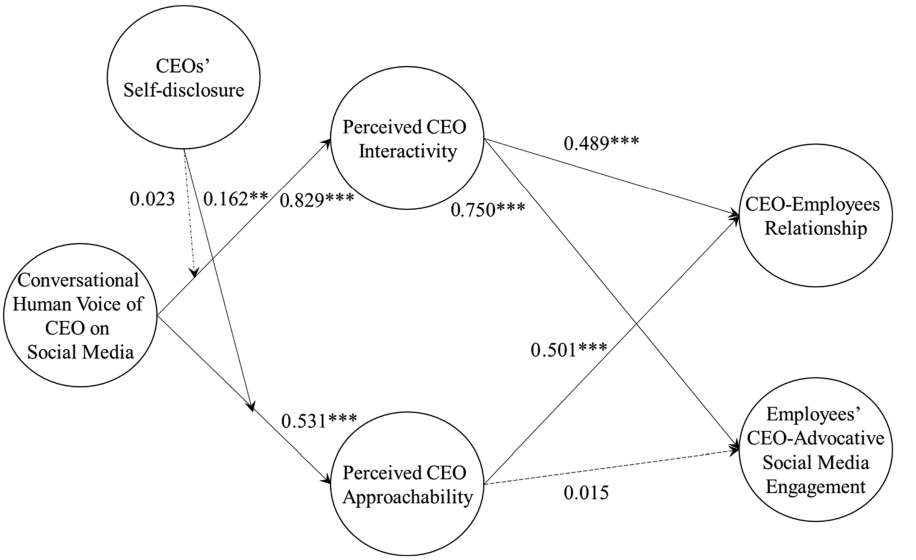
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Table 2. Results of confirmatory factor analysis (CFA)

Items	Standardized factor loadings	CR	AVE
CEO conversational human voice		0.920	0.591
C1	0.805		
C2	0.794		
C3	0.817		
C4	0.727		
C5	0.766		
C6	0.744		
C7	0.751		
C8	0.740		
CEO self-disclosure		0.871	0.630
D1	0.859		
D2	0.793		
D3	0.804		
D4	0.711		
Perceived CEO interactivity		0.914	0.681
I1	0.838		
I2	0.804		
I3	0.860		
I4	0.814		
I5	0.808		
Perceived CEO approachability		0.927	0.562
A1	0.607		
A2	0.827		
A3	0.761		
A4	0.754		
A5	0.736		
A6	0.769		
A7	0.678		
A8	0.790		
A9	0.787		
A10	0.764		
CEO-employee relationship			
Relational trust		0.909	0.625
T1	0.843		
T2	0.802		
T3	0.783		
T4	0.750		
T5	0.740		
T6	0.819		
Relational satisfaction		0.910	0.716
S1	0.859		
S2	0.852		
S3	0.841		
S4	0.833		
Employees' CEO-advocative social media engagement		0.928	0.645
E1	0.891		
E2	0.842		
E3	0.836		
E4	0.745		
E5	0.738		
E6	0.798		
E7	0.777		

Note(s): Composite reliabilities (CR); Average variance extracted (AVE)
All factor loadings are significant at $p < 0.001$ level
Source(s): Authors' work

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Note(s): $^{**}p < 0.01$, $^{***}p < 0.001$
Dotted lines indicate insignificant paths
Source(s): Authors' work

Figure 2. Results of the hypothesized model

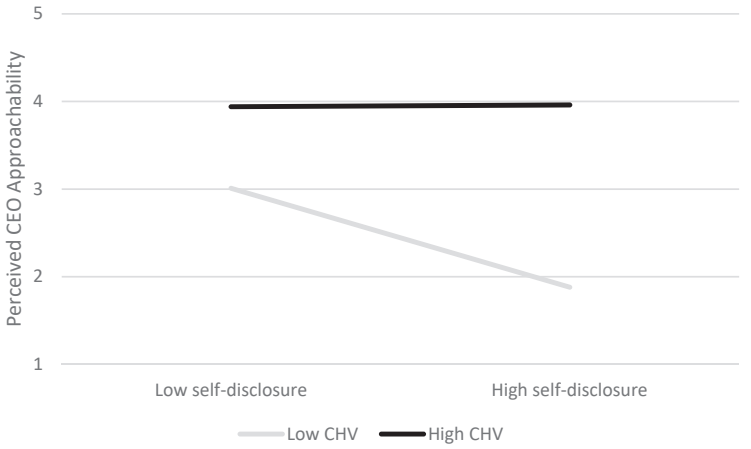
CEO interactivity was positively associated with social media engagement ($\beta = 0.750$, $p < 0.001$), perceived CEO approachability was not significantly associated with social media engagement ($\beta = 0.015$, $p = 0.489$). H5 is thus supported, while H6 is not supported. In sum, CEOs' CHV on social media enhanced employees' perceived interactivity and approachability of their CEOs, thereby increasing CEO-employee relationship. Perceived interactivity of CEOs played a particularly important role in fostering employees' CEO-advocative social media engagement.

Next, in H7, we tested the moderating roles of CEOs' personal disclosure on social media. In the model (Figure 2), the interaction term (CHV × personal disclosure) was positively and significantly associated with employees' perceived approachability of CEO ($\beta = 0.162$, $p < 0.01$), while it was not significantly associated with perceived CEO interactivity ($\beta = 0.023$, $p = 0.401$). The interaction pattern was further estimated by testing the nexuses between the CHV and perceived approachability of CEO at high and low (one *SD* above and below the mean respectively) CEO personal disclosure levels. At a high level of CEO's CHV, their self-disclosure did not make a significant difference (simple slope = 0.02, $p = 0.891$). However, at a low level of CHV, CEOs' self-disclosure significantly decreased employees' perceived approachability of their CEOs (simple slope = −1.13, $p < 0.001$) (see Figure 3). That is, self-disclosure is found to be effective in maintaining CEOs' approachability only when the CHV is manifested. H7a is thus not supported, while H7b is supported.

Discussion

This study tested a conceptual model linking CEOs' interpersonal communication approaches (e.g. conversational human voice, self-disclosure) on social media, perceived CEO approachability and interactivity, and employees' engagement. Our findings showed that CEOs' use of a conversational human voice on social media leads to perceptions of CEO

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Figure 3. The interaction effect between CEO's CHV and self-disclosure on employees' perceived approachability

interactivity and approachability, which in turn increases employees' CEO-advocative social media engagement and their relationships with CEOs. CEOs' self-disclosure had a conditional effect on their approachability: it was effective only when combined with a conversational human voice. This study offers significant theoretical and practical implications for effective leadership practices through social media.

Theoretical implications

With the public's growing expectations for transparency, openness, integrity, and authenticity from organizations and their leaders in the digital era (Ji and Hong, 2023; Men and Tsai, 2016), social media has emerged as a vital tool for corporate leaders to build meaningful relationships with the public and increase engagement (Yue *et al.*, 2023). This study extends prior scholarship, which has mainly focused on how CEOs use social media to communicate with the external public (e.g. consumers), by highlighting its importance from an internal perspective. We provide empirical evidence demonstrating how CEOs' combined use of a conversational human voice (CHV) and self-disclosure on social media positively affects employee perceptions and behaviors, suggesting social media as a critical instrument for effective leadership communication. We further reinforce the idea of CEOs as Chief "Engagement" Officers, who can leverage online platforms to foster employee interactions and support (Yue *et al.*, 2021).

Traditionally viewed as authoritative and possibly distant figures, CEOs can benefit from employing multiple communication channels to ensure effective internal communication (e.g. Lee, 2022). Our research contributes to this discourse by showing that the personal and interactive communication style of a CEO on social media can humanize the CEO and reduce employees' perceived distance from them (Yue *et al.*, 2021). Specifically, by adopting a conversational tone, expressing genuine interest and responsiveness to employee feedback, and sharing personal insights, CEOs can present themselves as accessible and engaging leaders. This approach encourages employees to participate more actively and cultivate a positive relationship with their leadership both offline and online.

Furthermore, as one of the first empirical analyses focusing on CEOs' communication styles on social media and their internal impacts, our study also enhances social presence theory in terms of effective technology use for internal and leadership communication.

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According to the theory, social media, with its greater social presence, has enabled CEOs to effectively build relationships with the public. Applying this concept to the CEO-employee relationship context, we found that CEOs' conversational communication style on social media fosters positive relationships between employees and their leaders, and encourages more active employee engagement on these platforms. Extending the idea from a previous study (Kelleher *et al.*, 2019), this insight addresses the important question of how leaders should communicate on social media for effective internal relations. Specifically, our findings indicate that when CEOs communicate in a personal, conversational, and engaging manner on social media, employees tend to perceive their CEOs as more approachable, interactive, relatable, and social. Utilizing a conversational human voice (CHV) also includes active listening to address employee feedback and demonstrating openness, transparency, accountability, and care for employees. Such communication in the digital environment enhances employees' trust and satisfaction with their CEOs. Therefore, our findings highlight that for CEOs, a conversational tone on social media can be a key internal relationship management tool to develop meaningful interpersonal interactions with employees.

Notably, our study advances social penetration theory by explaining how and when CEOs' personal disclosure can be effective in leveraging their positive attributes as communicators. Self-disclosure helps CEOs develop relationships with the public in more intimate and personal ways. Our study focused on the internal setting, and the results are consistent with a previous study (Kim and Sung, 2021), which found that CEOs' personal disclosure can be effective conditionally. We found that when CEOs use a warm, conversational style, the amount of personal information they share does not significantly impact how approachable they seem to employees. However, when CEOs did not use CHV but disclosed personal matters on social media, employees evaluated their approachability as low. This suggests that CEOs' use of CHV humanizes them, helping them to be seen as responsive and open-minded leaders who are concerned for employees' needs. Employees may thus feel comfortable seeing such a leader express their personal lives and opinions on social media. Therefore, CEOs' self-disclosure can be seen as appropriate and acceptable behavior by employees, encouraging them to view CEOs as approachable leaders. On the other hand, revealing CEOs' personal details without CHV does not align with relational norms between CEOs and employees. Without CHV, CEOs' self-disclosure may come across as less sincere or authentic, reducing the CEO's perceived approachability. In other words, CHV likely breaks down relational boundaries between senior leaders and employees, enabling personal disclosure as an acceptable communication strategy for CEOs to meet CEO-employee relational norms. By explicating when and how CEOs' personal disclosure facilitates positive responses from internal members, our study enriches the theoretical understanding of the effectiveness of leaders' self-disclosure on social media channels.

Finally, our study contributes to the growing body of literature on employees' social media engagement. On social media, employees play a crucial role as brand ambassadors and advocates when they create and share positive company-related content (Lee and Kim, 2021). Given the benefits of greater reach and establishing a reputable employer brand, many organizations have launched employee advocacy programs to promote employees' advocacy behaviors online. We found that CEOs' active and conversational commitment on social media motivates employees to more effectively represent their organization. This influence extends beyond direct communication with their CEOs and includes advocating for their organization across social media channels. While previous studies have examined the effectiveness of organizational-level internal communication and branding efforts (e.g. Thelen, 2020; Walden and Westerman, 2018), this study enriches the employee engagement and advocacy literature by highlighting CEOs as key drivers of employees' online engagement. It emphasizes the indispensable role of CEOs in fostering a culture of advocacy and engagement among employees, thereby reinforcing their significance as central figures in amplifying the company's online presence and reputation.

In addition, our findings revealed that CEOs' conversational human voice enhances employees' social media engagement through heightened perceptions of CEO interactivity,

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rather than perceived CEO approachability. This finding suggests that a leader's interactivity may be a more potent motivator for employees to engage with the CEOs' social media activities and, furthermore, to advocate on behalf of their organization and CEO. This could potentially exceed the impact of perceived CEO approachability. Overall, this study implies that CEOs' communication style on social media helps improve employee engagement on digital channels and indirectly boosts corporate reputation through the influence of internal members. Our findings highlight the vital role that corporate executives play in directly motivating and activating employees' behaviors through digital tools such as social media.

Practical implications

This study also provides significant practical implications for senior leaders, CEOs, and communication practitioners in corporations. As an increasing number of CEOs are using social media for professional and personal purposes, they should consider how their activities on social media may impact internal members. CEOs can use social media as a critical internal relationship management tool by positioning themselves as approachable, interactive, and personable leaders. Using a conversational human voice on social media not only helps employees perceive less of a power imbalance with their senior leaders but also encourages them to be more responsive and interact with the leaders on social media. CEOs often face challenges in interacting with their employees one-on-one, and employees often perceive their CEOs as distant figures. Using a conversational communication style on social media, for both personal and professional contents, can help build employees' trust and satisfaction with their CEOs.

To facilitate this practice, public relations and corporate communication professionals should educate senior leaders and help them understand the value of using a conversational voice on social media. Examples may include incorporating a friendly first-person narrative, using personal language, informal vocabulary and phrases, and including visual elements (e.g. emojis, pictures, photos). In discussing organizational issues, CEOs have the opportunity to bring a personal and human element to the discussion of corporate objectives, missions, values, and actions, thereby cultivating a sense of passion, unity, pride, and engagement that sets their posts apart from those of official organizational accounts. Importantly, utilizing a conversational voice facilitates the effectiveness of CEO's use of social media, especially when they want to disclose their personal lives (e.g. family, sociopolitical views). It helps to set the relational norm between CEOs and employees, thereby enhancing employees' positive responses to CEOs' personal disclosure. CEOs should be cautious when revealing their personal matters on social media. They should expect positive responses from employees when their tone is conversational and interactive. Otherwise, creating business-related posts (e.g. thought leadership) may be more appropriate to better meet employees' expectations.

Another essential aspect for CEOs is to exhibit their listening skills by adopting a conversational human tone, being receptive to dialogue, welcoming feedback, expressing genuine interest in employees' contributions, and providing responses that convey respect, understanding, and a willingness to engage.

Limitations and future studies

Our findings have some limitations that should be addressed in future studies. First, we only recruited employees working in large corporations, assuming a perceived distance between CEOs and their employees. As such, our results may not be easily generalized to employees in small- or medium-sized companies. For example, employees at startup companies may have different expectations regarding their CEO's communication style and social media usage, as they may feel a closer connection to their CEOs due to working more closely and communicating more frequently. Similarly, our sample included employees from diverse organizations and industries, making it difficult to control for multiple variations. Future studies could validate our model by testing its effectiveness with different employee samples

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(e.g. employees within a single organization) and identifying any unique findings. As the workforce landscape has become more dynamic since the pandemic, future studies should consider the diverse types of employees' current employment status (e.g. full-time, part-time, remote, hybrid) to enrich our understanding of the distinct impacts of CEOs' social media communication. Additionally, although we included several control variables in the SEM model, future research could explore the effects of other relevant factors related to CEOs' social media usage (e.g. the variety of social media platforms used, frequency of social media engagement) to provide a more comprehensive view of social media communication by senior leaders. Finally, employee-leader relationships and employee social media engagement may also be significantly influenced by their direct supervisors' social media practices. We recommend that future research explore the interactive effects between senior leaders' and direct supervisors' social media communication as internal relationship management strategies. Understanding this relational interplay could offer a more nuanced perspective on how different managerial levels contribute to alignment or divergence in employee behaviors, particularly in terms of social media advocacy.

Conclusion

This study significantly advances our understanding of how CEOs' interpersonal communication styles on social media—characterized by a conversational, human tone and strategic self-disclosure—can shape employee relationships and social media engagement. By demonstrating that these communication strategies enhance CEOs' approachability and interactivity, our research provides clear evidence of their effectiveness in fostering stronger connections between CEOs and employees, ultimately driving greater employee engagement on social media platforms. These findings contribute to the field by extending the application of social presence theory and social penetration theory to the internal organizational context, enriching the theoretical discourse on leadership communication. Our study underscores the potential of CEOs as central figures not only in external communication but also in shaping employee relational and behavioral responses through social media communication. Future research should further explore the applicability of these findings in diverse organizational settings and among different workforce dynamics, particularly as remote and hybrid work arrangements become more prevalent. Additionally, further investigation into the broader implications of digital communication strategies for leadership will continue to build on the foundation suggested by this study.

Notes

1. The second-order factor model for the CEO-employee relationship was found to be significantly better than the first-order model ($\Delta\chi^2(2) = 33.04$, $p < 0.001$), demonstrating that the sub-constructs are good indicators of the main latent variables.
2. The second-order factor model for employees' social media engagement was found to be significantly better than the first-order model ($\Delta\chi^2(2) = 32.22$, $p < 0.001$), demonstrating that the sub-constructs are good indicators of the main latent variables.
3. We used Hu and Bentler's (1998) criteria for the model fit: the root mean square error of approximation (RMSEA) < 0.08; comparative fit index (CFI) > 0.90; Tucker-Lewis index (TLI) > 0.90; and standardized root mean square residual (SRMR) < 0.90.

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Appendix
Measurement items

CEO conversational human voice (Kelleher and Miller, 2006)
On social media, my company's CEO . . .

(1) Invites people to conversation.

(2) Is open to dialogue.

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(3) Uses conversation-style communication.

(4) Tries to communicate in a human voice.

(5) Tries to be interesting in communication.

(6) Uses a sense of humor in communication.

(7) Attempts to make communication enjoyable.

(8) Provides prompt feedback addressing criticism in a direct but uncritical manner.

Perceived CEO interactivity (McMillan and Hwang, 2002)
My company's CEO . . .

(1) Enables two-way communication.

(2) Enables concurrent communication.

(3) Enables interpersonal interaction.

(4) Is interactive.

(5) Enables conversation.

Perceived CEO approachability (Porter *et al.*, 2007)
My company's CEO is . . .

(1) Warm.

(2) Open.

(3) Accessible.

(4) Responsive.

(5) Easy to talk to.

(6) Sociable.

(7) Sensitive.

(8) Receptive.

(9) Welcoming.

(10) Thoughtful.

CEO-Employee relationship (Hon and Grunig, 1999)
Relational trust

(1) My company's CEO can be relied on to keep his/her promises.

(2) My company's CEO treats employees fairly and justly.

(3) My company's CEO is concerned about employees whenever he/she makes an important decision.

(4) My company's CEO takes the opinions of employees into account when making decisions.

(5) My company's CEO has the ability to accomplish what he/she says he/she will do.

(6) I feel very confident about my CEO's skills.

Relational satisfaction

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(1) I am happy with my company's CEO overall.

(2) Both my company's CEO and its employees benefit from the relationship.

(3) Most employees are happy in their interactions with my company's CEO.

(4) I am pleased with the relationship my company's CEO has established with its employees.

Employees' CEO-advocative social media engagement (Walden and Westerman, 2018)
How likely would you . . .

(1) "Like" the CEO's posts on social media?

(2) "Share" the CEO's posts on social media?

(3) Make comments on your CEO's posts on social media?

(4) Speak favorably about your CEO/organization on social media?

(5) Say positive things about your CEO/organization on social media?

(6) Defend your CEO/organization's action when someone says something negative?

(7) Tell others positively about your CEO/organization in general?

CEO self-disclosure (self-developed)
On social media, how often does your company's CEO . . .

(1) Update his/her personal/family life status?

(2) Update his/her work lives?

(3) Share his/her political opinions?

(4) Voices out on important sociopolitical matters?

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